In a Shared Land

By Julia Alvarez and Naomi Shihab Nye

INTRODUCTION

According to the UN, Not since World War II have so many people been on the move. Violent conflict has displaced 38 million within their own countries and forced another 22 million to flee across a border. But numbers that vast defy understanding . . . so today we make it personal with 2 poems that eloquently describe what it means to be adrift. . . In a Strange Land by Julia Alvarez and Naomi Shihab Nye.

Before his assassination on a dark highway on 30 May 1961, the Dominican dictator, Rafael Trujillo, ruled with an iron fist for almost 30 years. Those who dared to oppose him were imprisoned, tortured and murdered. In her poem "Exile," Julia Alvarez shares her childhood memory of fleeing her homeland for America. You see, her grandfather had been charged with conspiracy to overthrow Trujillo, and the lives of his entire family were at risk.

Exile by Julia Alvarez

The night we fled the country, Papi,
you told me we were going to the beach,
hurried me to get dressed along with the others,
while posted at a window, you looked out

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at a curfew-darkened Ciudad Trujillo,
speaking in worried whispers to your brothers,
which car to take, who'd be willing to drive it,
what explanation to give should we be discovered . . .

On the way to the beach, you added, eyeing me.
The uncles fell in, chuckling phony chuckles,
What a good time she'll have learning to swim!
Back in my sisters' room Mami was packing

a hurried bag, allowing one toy apiece,
her red eyes belying her explanation:
a week at the beach so Papi can get some rest.
She dressed us in our best dresses, party shoes.

Something was off, I knew, but I was young
and didn't think adult things could go wrong.
So as we quietly filed out of the house
we wouldn't see again for another decade,

I let myself lie back in deep waters,
my arms out like Jesus' on His cross,
and instead of sinking down like I'd always done,
magically, that night, I could stay up,

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floating out, past the driveway, past the gates,
in the black Ford, Papi grim at the wheel,
winding through the back roads, stroke by difficult stroke,
out on the highway, heading toward the coast.

Past the checkpoint, we raced toward the airport,
my sisters crying when we turned before
the family beach house, Mami consoling,
there was a better surprise in store for us!

She couldn't tell, though, until… until we were there.
But I had already swum ahead and guessed
some loss much larger than I understood,
More danger than the deep end of the pool.

At the dark, deserted airport we waited.
All night in a fitful sleep, I swam.
At dawn the plane arrived, and as we boarded,
Papi, you turned, your eyes scanned the horizon

as if you were trying to sight a distant swimmer,
your hand frantically waving her back in,
for you knew as we stepped inside the cabin
That a part of both of us had been set adrift.

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Weeks later, wandering our new city, hand in hand,
you tried to explain the wonders: escalators
as moving belts; elevators: pulleys and rope;
blonde hair and blue eyes: a genetic code.

We stopped before a summery display window
at Macy's, The World's Largest Department Store,
to admire a family outfitted for the beach:
the handsome father, slim and sure of himself,

so unlike you, Papi, with your thick mustache,
your three-piece suit, your fedora hat, your accent.
And by his side a girl who looked like Heidi
in my story book waded in colored plastic.

We stood awhile, marveling at America,
both of us trying hard to feel luckier
than we felt, both of us pointing out
the beach pails, the shovels, the sandcastles

no wave would ever topple, the red and blue boats.
And when we backed away, we saw our reflections
superimposed, big-eyed, dressed too formally
with all due respect as visitors to this country.

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Or like, Papi, two swimmers looking down
at the quite surface of our island waters,
seeing their faces right before plunging in,
eager, afraid, not yet sure of the outcome.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Julia Alvarez
Book: The Other Side / ElOotro Lado
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TRANSITION

Today, the United States is experiencing its second great wave of immigration, a movement of people that has profound implications for a society that by tradition pays homage to its immigrant roots at the same time confronts complex and deeply ingrained ethnic and racial divisions. But I don't want to live in a divided world. Fear and hatred of "the other" festering just below the slow boil of the American "melting pot."

No . . . I want to live in a world where people connect across boundaries of race, ethnicity, geography and every other facet of identity. "This is the world I want to live in. The shared world."

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Wandering Around an Albuquerque Airport Terminal (aka Gate A-4) by Naomi Shihab Nye

After learning my flight was detained 4 hours,
I heard the announcement:
If anyone in the vicinity of gate 4-A understands any Arabic,
Please come to the gate immediately.
Well—one pauses these days. Gate 4-A was my own gate. I
went there.
An older woman in full traditional Palestinian dress,
Just like my grandma wore, was crumpled to the floor,
wailing loudly.
Help, said the flight service person. Talk to her. What is her
Problem? we told her the flight was going to be four hours
late and she
Did this.
I put my arm around her and spoke to her haltingly.
Shu dow-a, shu- biduck habibti, stani stani schway, min
fadlick,
Sho bit se-wee?
The minute she heard any words she knew—however
poorly used—

She stopped crying.

She thought our flight had been canceled entirely.

She needed to be in El Paso for some major medical
treatment the

Following day. I said no, no, we're fine, you'll get there, just
late,

Who is picking you up? Let's call him and tell him.

We called her son and I spoke with him in English.

I told him I would stay with his mother till we got on the
plane and

Would ride next to her—Southwest.

She talked to him. Then we called her other sons just for
the fun of it.

Then we called my dad and he and she spoke for a while in
Arabic and

Found out of course they had ten shared friends.

Then I thought just for the heck of it why not call some
Palestinian

Poets I know and let them chat with her. This all took up
about 2 hours.

She was laughing a lot by then. Telling about her life.
Answering

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Questions.

She had pulled a sack of homemade mamool cookies—little
powdered

Sugar crumbly mounds stuffed with dates and nuts—out of
her bag—

And was offering them to all the women at the gate.

To my amazement, not a single woman declined one. It was
like a

Sacrament. The traveler from Argentina, the traveler from
California,

The lovely woman from Laredo—we were all covered with
the same

Powdered sugar. And smiling. There are no better cookies.

And then the airline broke out the free beverages from
huge coolers—

Non-alcoholic—and the two little girls for our flight, one
African

American, one Mexican American—ran around serving us
all apple juice

And lemonade and they were covered with powdered sugar
too.

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And I noticed my new best friend—by now we were holding
hands—
Had a potted plant poking out of her bag, some medicinal
thing,
With green furry leaves. Such an old country traveling
tradition. Always
Carry a plant. Always stay rooted to somewhere.
And I looked around that gate of late and weary ones and
thought,
This is the world I want to live in. The shared world.
Not a single person in this gate—once the crying of
confusion stopped
—has seemed apprehensive about any other person.
They took the cookies. I wanted to hug all those other
women too.
This can still happen anywhere.
Not everything is lost.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Naomi Shihab Nye
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